SC CODEWORKS

Solutions To Grow Your Logistics Business

THE ULTIMATE GUIDE TO WAREHOUSE MANAGEMENT SYSTEMS

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INTRODUCTION: WHY A WMS MATTERS

WHAT IS A WMS?

A warehouse management system (WMS) is basically the brain of your warehouse. It's software that helps track and manage everything inside the warehouse—from inventory levels to orders being shipped. It tells workers where to find products, helps ensure everything is in the right place, and keeps things running smoothly. Think of it as a super-organized digital assistant that makes sure the right products get to the right places at the right times, helping the whole operation run faster and more efficiently.

THE IMPORTANCE OF A WMS

Think of a WMS as the control center for everything that happens inside a warehouse. Without it, you're relying on manual processes, paper checklists, or scattered spreadsheets to manage thousands of moving parts—like tracking inventory, fulfilling orders, and keeping workers on task.

A WMS brings order to chaos. It tells you exactly what's in your warehouse, where it is, and what needs to happen next. It helps your team work faster and smarter by guiding them through tasks like receiving products, picking and packing orders, and shipping things out on time. It also helps reduce mistakes, prevent stockouts, and keep customers happy.

In short, a WMS helps you run a more efficient, accurate, and scalable warehouse operation—and in today's fast-moving supply chain world, that kind of control and visibility is essential.

WHO SHOULD USE THIS GUIDE?

This guide is for anyone who works in or around a warehouse—whether you're on the floor, managing operations, or making big-picture decisions. If you're exploring new solutions to help your warehouse run more efficiently, or you're outgrowing spreadsheets and paper processes, you're in the right place. The guide is also a great resource if you're new to the industry and want to understand how modern warehouse technology works, or if you're already using a WMS but wondering if it's still the right fit. No matter your role or experience level, this guide is designed to help you make informed decisions, without jargon or pressure.

WHAT TO EXPECT

In this guide, we'll walk you through everything you need to know about warehouse management systems—from the basics of what a WMS is and why it matters to the different types of solutions available and the key features to look for. You'll also find practical advice on how to implement a system, tips for choosing the right one for your business, and insights into where WMS technology is headed. Whether you're just getting started or reevaluating your current setup, this guide is here to help you make confident, informed decisions. We've even included some bonus tools and resources to support you along the way.

CHAPTER 1: THE BASICS OF WMS

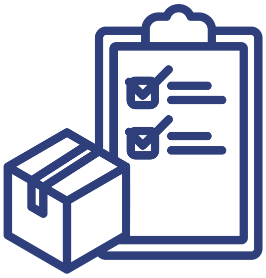
EVOLUTION OF THE MODERN WMS

Warehouse management systems have been an essential part of warehouse operations for as long as warehouses themselves have existed. Even the early practice of tracking inventory on handwritten cards could be considered a form of WMS. But as technology has advanced, so have the systems used to manage inventory. Early WMS solutions required substantial physical space, with bulky dot matrix printers, large computers, and dedicated servers for data storage. Over time, WMS software has became more compact, accessible, and sophisticated. It's also more integrated with other systems, enabling a more seamless and cohesive supply chain. Modern WMS providers continue to innovate, keeping pace with the rapid advancements in warehouse technology to meet the evolving demands of the industry.

WHAT DOES A WMS DO?

As the "brain" of warehouse operations, a WMS plays a crucial role in keeping everything running smoothly. It helps bring order to the often-chaotic environment of a busy warehouse. At its core, a WMS ensures accurate inventory management, organizes key processes like receiving and shipping, boosts operational efficiency, and generates reports that provide valuable insights. The WMS's role is broad, and in the following sections, we'll dive into the core features it should offer to keep your warehouse functioning at its best.

CORE FEATURES OF A WMS



INVENTORY MANAGEMENT

The inventory management feature of a WMS allows for precise control over stock levels, ensuring that adjustments can be made when necessary. It tracks important details like stock conditions, locations within the warehouse, and product shelf life. Additionally, WMS systems can implement inventory methods like FIFO (first in, first out), FEFO (first expired, first out), LIFO (last in, first out), and LEFO (last expired, first out) to meet specific operational needs. Inventory management also makes regular cycle counts and physical inventories easier by providing ongoing accuracy in stock levels.

ORDER MANAGEMENT

Order management in a WMS starts with the creation of orders, ensuring they are accurately entered into the system. From there, the WMS streamlines the picking process, helping warehouse workers retrieve the correct items efficiently. It also supports load consolidation, grouping items from multiple orders into a single shipment to optimize space and reduce shipping costs. The system generates the necessary labels for shipping, making sure all orders are properly identified. Additionally, different picking strategies, such as batch picking, wave picking, or zone picking, can be employed depending on the warehouse's specific needs and the order volume, further enhancing efficiency.

BARCODE SCANNING & RFID INTEGRATION

While barcode scanning and RFID integration aren’t required features of a WMS, they’re definitely powerful add-ons that can make a big difference. When products are barcoded, it’s much easier and faster for warehouse teams to scan items during receiving or picking, which cuts down on errors and saves time. This simple upgrade adds a lot of accuracy and efficiency to day-to-day operations.

REAL-TIME DATA & REPORTING

Real-time data and reporting are some of the most valuable features of a WMS. With so much information being collected—from inventory movement to order status to labor activity—a WMS should do more than just store data; it should help you make sense of it. When every action in the warehouse is tracked and updated in real time, you have a clear, accurate snapshot of what's happening at any given moment. Good reporting tools can highlight where you are in your daily workflow, flag exceptions or bottlenecks, and help you track key performance indicators (KPIs) like order accuracy, dock-to-stock time, or pick rates. Ultimately, reporting should help tell the story of your operation—what's working, what needs attention, and where you can improve.

CONFIGURABLE SLOTTING RULES & OPTIMIZED PICK ROUTING

While a WMS won't design your warehouse for you, it does play a key role in making your space work smarter. Through configurable slotting rules and optimized pick routing, the system helps reduce unnecessary travel time and streamlines both putaway and picking processes. For example, the WMS can prioritize locations based on item size, weight, pick frequency, or special handling requirements. It can also guide operators along efficient travel paths using pick-sequencing logic based on preset routing strategies. Whether you're setting up a pick line, managing fast- vs. slow-moving inventory, or simply trying to make the most of your current layout, a WMS helps ensure that every move—from putaway to picking—is intentional and efficient.

LABOR MANAGEMENT

Labor management in a WMS helps direct warehouse operators to their next task by providing them with a work queue to ensure they stay focused and productive. The system can automatically assign tasks to workers based on priorities or the established schedule, making sure that the most urgent jobs are handled first. It also optimizes routes for operators, reducing unnecessary movement and improving overall efficiency. By monitoring performance, the WMS helps maximize productivity and minimize downtime, helping warehouse staff work as efficiently as possible throughout their shifts.

SHIPPING & RECEIVING

The shipping and receiving process in a WMS starts with managing inbound shipments, including receiving and verifying advance shipping notices (ASNs) to prepare for incoming goods. Once shipments arrive, the WMS streamlines the receiving process, ensuring items are checked in and put away in the correct locations quickly and efficiently. The system generates labels for proper identification and tracks the time spent on each task to monitor efficiency. The WMS can also support dock scheduling, optimizing the flow of goods in and out of the warehouse while managing door assignments to ensure smooth operations. Finally, the system helps with load-out by organizing the shipment process, keeping goods properly prepared and dispatched on time.

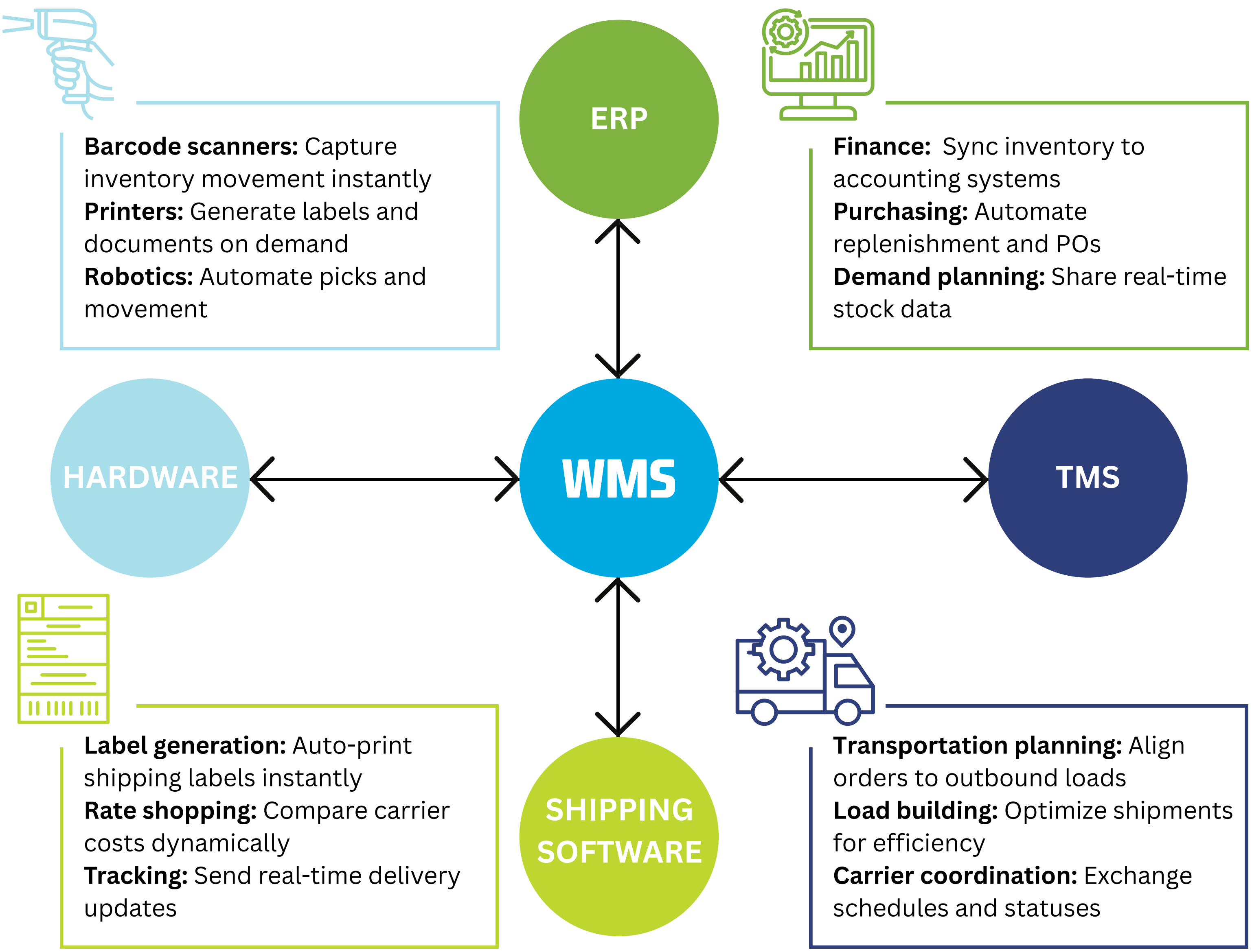
RETURNS MANAGEMENT

Returns are a fact of life in warehouse operations, and a good WMS helps make the process a lot less painful. When items come back into the warehouse—whether they're damaged, the wrong size, or just not needed—a WMS helps track and manage each step of the return. It starts with receiving the item, verifying it against the original order or return authorization, and then directing it to the appropriate next step: restocking, sending for inspection or repair, or flagging for disposal. The WMS records every return in real time, so your inventory stays accurate, and your team knows exactly where each item is and what needs to happen next. It can also help speed up the process for customers by automating key steps, reducing turnaround time, and making sure returns don't create bottlenecks. Whether you're handling a few returns a week or managing high-volume reverse logistics, a WMS brings structure and visibility to a part of the operation that can easily get messy.

INTEGRATION WITH OTHER SYSTEMS

One of the most powerful aspects of a WMS is its ability to integrate with other systems across your business. A well-integrated WMS connects seamlessly with tools like ERP systems (for things like WIP inventory and accounting functions), TMS platforms (for transportation planning and carrier coordination), and parcel shipping systems (for label generation, rate shopping, and tracking). These integrations ensure that information flows smoothly between systems, reducing the need for manual entry and helping your entire operation stay in sync. WMS platforms can also handle a variety of data formats—like EDI (X12, EDIFACT), XML, and IDOCs—which makes it easier to connect with different partners, customers, and systems regardless of their setup. Whether you're sharing order data with your ERP or updating shipping statuses through your TMS, integration helps create a connected, end-to-end supply chain that's faster, more accurate, and easier to manage.

WMS OVERVIEW



CHAPTER 2: BENEFITS OF IMPLEMENTING A WMS

Implementing a WMS is a big step for any business, but it's one that brings a ton of rewards. In this section, we'll walk you through the key benefits of having a WMS in place, from improving efficiency and accuracy to cutting costs and boosting customer satisfaction. Whether you're looking to streamline operations, reduce errors, or simply deliver better service to your customers, a WMS can help take your warehouse to the next level. By leveraging the power of real-time data and automation, you can make smarter decisions, optimize workflows, and ultimately improve your bottom line.

INCREASED EFFICIENCY

One of the biggest benefits of using a WMS is how much more efficient your operation can become. Everything from receiving to shipping gets a boost. You can plan ahead and know exactly what's coming in, which makes receiving faster and more accurate—no more guessing on quantities or scrambling to track down lot codes. On the outbound side, the WMS helps you prepare for what needs to be picked and shipped each day keeping your team focused and organized.

Picking becomes quicker and smarter too, with the system guiding operators on the most efficient routes and using commit rules to get orders out the door faster. Even trailer loading gets more strategic so you're making the best use of space and time. Plus, with the WMS connecting to other systems or enabling automated workflows, you can take even more manual work off your plate and keep things moving without missing a beat.

30%
INCREASE

HOW MUCH MORE EFFICIENT?

Many operations see a **20–30% increase in productivity** after implementing a WMS, especially in picking and packing. Error rates often drop dramatically too, which reduces rework and saves time across the board.

Want to track your progress? Here are a few metrics that can help you measure efficiency before and after a WMS.

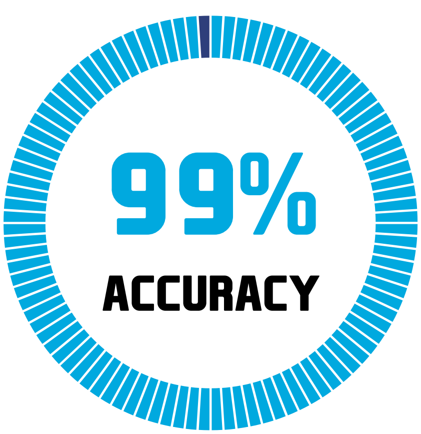
- **Receiving throughput**: Units or pallets received per hour
- **Pick rate**: Lines or units picked per hour
- **Order cycle time**: How long it takes from order receipt to shipment
- **Dock-to-stock time**: How quickly received items are put away and ready to ship
- **Labor utilization**: Time spent on productive tasks vs. idle time
- **Inventory accuracy**: A big one that directly impacts efficiency across the board

By tracking these KPIs, you can clearly see where you're improving and where there's still opportunity to streamline even further.

BETTER INVENTORY CONTROL

Another major advantage of a WMS is the huge boost in inventory accuracy and the reduction of costly errors. When you have full visibility into the life of your inventory—from the moment it's received to the moment it ships—you're in control. A WMS tracks every move your inventory makes, whether it's being relocated, adjusted, picked partially, or placed on hold. You can freeze items for quality checks, prioritize high-demand products for picking, and stop problem inventory before it causes downstream issues.

By shifting away from manual processes and letting the system act as a built-in safeguard, you drastically reduce the chances of human error. No more miscounts, misplaced inventory, or guessing which lot code to pick—your WMS keeps everyone on the same page and every item where it should be.



WHAT KIND OF IMPACT CAN YOU EXPECT?

Many warehouses report **99% inventory accuracy** (or higher) after WMS implementation, compared to the 85–90% range with manual processes. That means fewer stockouts, less rework, and more reliable fulfillment.

Ways to measure accuracy improvements

- **Inventory accuracy rate:** The difference between system records and physical counts
- **Picking error rate:** Incorrect items, quantities, or locations during fulfillment
- **Cycle count accuracy:** How often your ongoing inventory checks match what's expected
- **Return rate due to errors:** Fewer mistakes leading to fewer returns
- **Order accuracy:** Ensuring the right products go to the right place, the first time

When accuracy improves, so does customer satisfaction, labor efficiency, and overall confidence in your operation. A good WMS helps make that happen by keeping the details tight and the guesswork out of the equation.

COST SAVINGS

While a WMS can feel like a big investment up front, it's important to look at the bigger picture—because the right system can actually save you money in the long run. With increased efficiency across operations, many warehouses find they can reduce head count, both on the floor and in administrative roles. Tasks that once took hours (or teams of people) can often be handled faster and more accurately with fewer hands involved.

You'll also cut down on smaller—but still meaningful—costs like paper, toner, and printed pick tickets. Going digital doesn't just streamline your processes; it also reduces your office supply bills.

Higher inventory accuracy can lead to fewer charge-backs, reduced lost sales, and less time spent dealing with costly mistakes. Plus, better slotting and space optimization often mean you can store more with the space you already have—or even delay the need for a larger facility. In some cases, businesses are able to take on new customers or more volume without adding square footage, staff, or overhead.

Where can you see savings?

- **Labor costs:** Streamlined processes resulting in fewer hours needed
- **Error-related costs:** Fewer mis-picks, miscounts, and chargebacks
- **Supplies:** Less printing, fewer labels, and fewer manual processes
- **Storage utilization:** Getting more out of your existing space
- **Carrying costs and lost revenue:** Less overstocking and stockouts due to more accurate inventory

BONUS: Some operations report **ROI on a WMS within 12–24 months,** depending on the size and complexity of the business. The key is to treat it like an investment in long-term operational health—not just another software expense.

IMPROVED CUSTOMER SATISFACTION

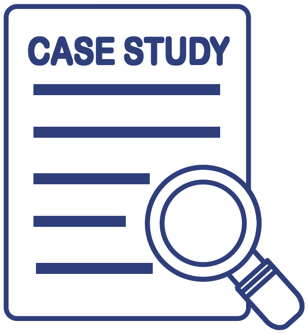
At the end of the day, everything that happens inside your warehouse affects your customers—and a WMS plays a big role in creating a better experience for them. When your operation is running smoothly, you're able to receive and ship orders on time, keep inventory accurate, and fulfill what customers are expecting, when they expect it.

A WMS helps orders go out correctly and promptly, which reduces delays, mis-shipments, and the frustration that comes with them. And because all your data is in one place and updated in real time, it's much easier to provide fast, accurate answers when customers have questions or requests. Whether they need a tracking update, inventory availability, or a historical report, you're equipped to respond confidently and quickly—building trust with every interaction.

How a WMS supports better customer experiences

- **Fewer shipping errors:** Fewer returns or complaints
- **Faster order fulfillment:** Better on-time delivery rates
- **Real-time visibility:** Quicker, clearer communication
- **Better data access:** More accurate reporting and faster issue resolution

Happy customers come back—and they tell others. By improving reliability, responsiveness, and accuracy, a WMS becomes a direct contributor to customer satisfaction and long-term loyalty. It's not just about getting products out the door—it's about building a reputation for service your customers can count on.



Example case study: To see the power of seamless integration in action, look no further than this example: A growing logistics provider partnered with Codeworks to streamline communication between their WMS and other critical tools. Their goal was to enable real-time tracking, accurate order processing, and a more responsive warehouse environment. The result? A smooth system transition, improved operational efficiency, and the ability to take on new business opportunities with confidence.

READ THE FULL CASE STUDY

CHAPTER 3: TYPES OF WMS SYSTEMS

ON-PREMISES vs. CLOUD-BASED WMS

On-premises solutions are hosted and run on local servers within the company's facilities. While they offer control over data and operations, they also come with high initial costs for hardware, software, and infrastructure. Additionally, ongoing maintenance, complex upgrades, and limited scalability can present challenges, especially as a business grows. Accessibility is restricted, typically requiring on-site presence, which can hinder flexibility, and security is entirely the company's responsibility, adding a layer of risk.

ON-PREMISES WMS

PROS

Complete control over your system and data: Since the system is installed on-site, you have direct control over the hardware, software, and data management.

Customization: On-premises solutions can be tailored to fit the specific needs of your business, offering flexibility in terms of configuration.

Security: You manage your own security protocols, which can be an advantage for organizations with strict data protection regulations or security requirements.

CONS

High upfront costs: Implementing an on-premises WMS involves significant costs for hardware, software licenses, and infrastructure setup. These upfront costs can be a heavy burden, especially for smaller businesses.

Ongoing maintenance and upgrades: On-premises systems require continuous maintenance, updates, and support, which means additional costs for IT staff or outsourcing. There's also the need for periodic hardware upgrades to keep the system running smoothly.

Scalability challenges: As your business grows, scaling an on-premises system can be expensive and complex. Adding new hardware and infrastructure may be required, which can result in additional investment and effort.

On the other hand, cloud-based WMS (SaaS solutions) are hosted by a service provider and accessible via the internet. These systems offer significant advantages, including lower up-front costs, predictable subscription fees, and easy scalability as your business needs grow. With cloud solutions, you benefit from automatic updates, enhanced security, and accessibility from anywhere, making them ideal for businesses that require flexibility and real-time data. Cloud solutions also reduce the burden on IT departments and are easier to integrate with existing systems.

CLOUD-BASED (SaaS) WMS

PROS

Lower upfront costs: Cloud-based systems operate on a subscription model, so there's no need for hefty investments in hardware and infrastructure. This makes it much more affordable initially, especially for smaller businesses or startups.

Scalability: SaaS solutions can easily grow with your business. As your needs increase, you can simply upgrade your subscription or add additional features, without worrying about purchasing new hardware or dealing with complex installations.

Enhanced security: Many SaaS providers invest heavily in security infrastructure, including encryption, regular security audits, and disaster recovery plans, which can offer more robust data protection than many on-premises solutions.

Faster deployment: A cloud-based WMS can be implemented much faster compared to on-premises systems, often in a matter of weeks or even days, which makes it a good option for businesses looking for quick integration.

CONS

Recurring costs: While the initial investment is lower, cloud-based systems require ongoing subscription fees, which could add up over time. This could potentially be more expensive than a one-time on-premises solution, depending on the duration of use.

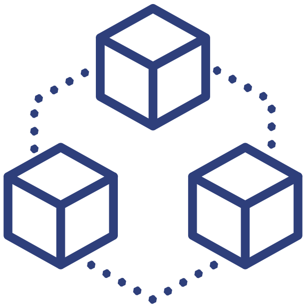
Less control over data and security: With a cloud-based solution, the provider manages your data, which means you're trusting them with your business information. Some businesses may have concerns about data privacy or security, especially in highly regulated industries.

Potential data migration challenges: If you decide to switch to a different system or move back to an on-premises solution, migrating data from the cloud can be a complex and time-consuming process.

Both on-premises and cloud-based WMS solutions can be great choices depending on your specific needs. On-premises systems may be better for businesses that require full control over their data and infrastructure or that have specific regulatory requirements. Cloud-based solutions, however, are generally more cost-effective, scalable, and easier to implement, making them an attractive option for businesses looking to streamline operations without heavy up-front investment. Ultimately, the decision comes down to factors such as budget, business growth, and the level of flexibility or control required for your operation.

MODULAR WMS vs. INTEGRATED WMS

When choosing a WMS, businesses can typically select between modular WMS and fully integrated WMS solutions. Each has its advantages and drawbacks depending on your business needs, growth plans, and budget.



Modular WMS is more of a "build-your-own" solution. With a modular system, you start with the basics, typically core features such as receiving, inventory management, and basic picking. As your needs grow, you can add additional modules like advanced reporting, automated picking, or integrations with shipping or ERP systems. This type of WMS offers flexibility because you only pay for the features you need at the time. It's ideal for businesses that are in early stages, have limited needs, or want to spread out their investment. It can be a cost-effective solution in the short term, as you can start small and expand as needed.

However, as your operation scales, a modular WMS can become more costly. Adding and integrating additional modules can increase complexity and require more time for setup and maintenance. As more features are added, you may find yourself paying for various components separately, and if your growth accelerates quickly, the total cost of ownership can rise. Furthermore, integrating all the separate modules seamlessly can become challenging, especially as new modules or updates are introduced.

MODULAR WMS

PROS

Cost-effective at first, as you only pay for the features you need

Flexible—add only the modules that fit your current operation

Ideal for smaller or growing businesses that want to control their costs

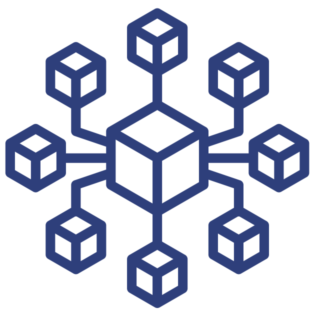
CONS

Can become **expensive** as you add more modules

Can lead to **compatibility issues**

Can end up paying for more modules than originally planned if your needs change quickly.

Requires more management and decision-making on which modules to select



On the flip side, a f**ully integrated WMS** offers a comprehensive solution with all features included from the start. With this type of system, you don’t have to worry about adding individual modules as your needs evolve – everything is included, and you have full access to all the system’s capabilities right out of the box. This approach is beneficial for businesses looking for scalability without having to manage multiple integrations or additional purchases later down the line.

A fully integrated WMS is typically more streamlined in terms of implementation since everything works together from the start. It can easily accommodate a company’s growth without the need to purchase additional components or modules. These systems are often more cohesive and easier to manage, with fewer compatibility or integration issues between modules.

However, the main disadvantage of a fully integrated WMS is the up-front cost. You’re paying for the full suite of features, even if you don’t use them all immediately. This can make the initial investment significantly higher than a modular system. Additionally, if you have minimal needs at first, you may find yourself paying for a lot of functionality you won’t use right away.

In terms of scalability, a fully integrated WMS tends to be more flexible long-term. As your business grows, you can start using additional features as needed without having to worry about purchasing new modules or facing compatibility issues.

FULLY INTEGRATED WMS

PROS	CONS
A**ccess to all features** right from the start—no need to purchase add-ons	**Higher upfront costs**, as you pay for all features upfront
Ideal for businesses planning to **scale quickl**y or requiring a comprehensive solution	May require **paying for features you don't need** or use immediately
Easier integration and fewer compatibility issues, as everything is designed to work together	May be **overkill for businesses with simpler operations** or limited needs in the early stages
Typically more **streamlined** for long-term growth	

Ultimately, the choice between a modular and fully integrated WMS depends on the size and scale of your business, your growth plans, and your budget. If you're a smaller operation with specific needs, a **modular WMS** might offer the most value by allowing you to start with just the essentials and add functionality as you grow. However, if you're looking for a solution that will scale seamlessly with your business and provide you with a comprehensive set of tools from the start, a **fully integrated WMS** could be the better choice, despite the higher initial investment.

In either case, both types of systems offer the flexibility to meet your operational goals, but it's important to carefully assess your business's current and future needs before deciding which model will serve you best.

INDUSTRY-SPECIFIC WMS

Not all warehouse management systems are created equally. Many WMS solutions are specifically tailored to meet the unique needs of different industries. These solutions take into account the distinctive workflows, requirements, and challenges each industry faces, ensuring that operations run smoothly and efficiently. Below is a breakdown of the key industry-specific WMS solutions.

RETAIL

Retail operations require a specialized WMS to manage complex and fast-moving inventories. Here's why a retail-focused WMS is necessary.

- **Point-of-sale (POS) integration:** Retail businesses require seamless integration with their POS systems to ensure that inventory levels are updated in real time as items are sold. This ensures accurate stock information across all channels.
- **Multiple locations and inventory management:** Retailers often have many store locations, each with its own inventory needs. A WMS tailored for retail allows businesses to manage inventory across different stores, warehouses, and distribution centers, ensuring stock is allocated efficiently and reducing the risk of stockouts or overstock.
- **Demand planning integration:** Retailers need to forecast and plan for demand, particularly around seasonal events or promotions. An industry-specific WMS can help optimize stock levels based on historical sales data, ensuring that the right products are available at the right time.
- **Store-level management:** Retail-specific WMS solutions allow businesses to manage individual store-level stock and perform tasks like store replenishment, transfers, and adjustments from a centralized location.

E-COMMERCE

E-commerce businesses face unique challenges when it comes to managing high-volume orders, fast shipping, and direct customer interactions. Here's how a WMS with an e-commerce focus addresses these needs.

- **High volume and fast turnaround:** E-commerce businesses often deal with a high volume of orders that need to be processed quickly. A WMS designed for e-commerce ensures fast order fulfillment and efficient picking and packing workflows, helping meet customer expectations for fast delivery.

- **Integration with shipping software:** Seamless integration with third-party shipping software is critical for e-commerce businesses, as it enables accurate label printing, shipment tracking, and streamlined returns management.

- **Direct consumer communication:** E-commerce WMS solutions enable businesses to send timely updates to consumers, including order confirmation, shipping notifications, and tracking information, enhancing the customer experience.

- **Payment and ordering information management:** E-commerce businesses need to manage payments, order statuses, and inventory levels in real time. A WMS tailored to e-commerce integrates directly with shopping carts, payment gateways, and inventory management systems to ensure a smooth order-to-shipment process.

MANUFACTURING

Manufacturing companies have unique needs related to inventory management, production scheduling, and supply chain visibility. A manufacturing-focused WMS helps companies maintain tight control over their inventory, ensure materials are available for production, and improve efficiency across the entire production process.

- **Managing tight inventory:** Manufacturing operations often deal with just-in-time inventory management. A WMS designed for this industry helps ensure that raw materials, parts, and components are available when needed, without tying up too much capital in stock.

- **Production line timeliness:** A manufacturing-specific WMS ensures that inventory is available at the right time and place on the production line. This is critical to prevent delays in manufacturing processes that can affect delivery schedules.

- **High inventory turns:** Manufacturing companies typically deal with high inventory turnover, as raw materials are quickly transformed into finished products. WMS solutions for manufacturing help manage inventory flow efficiently, delivering fast and accurate stock movements.

- **Instant visibility for procurement and planning:** Manufacturing WMS solutions often integrate with procurement and planning systems to give real-time visibility of inventory levels, demand, and supply chain processes. This allows businesses to plan better, reduce lead times, and improve overall production scheduling.

3PLs

For 3PL companies, a WMS must handle multiple client accounts, varied shipping methods, and additional value-added services. Here's how a 3PL-specific WMS can help.

- **Managing multiple clients:** 3PL providers juggle many different types of businesses under one roof, which means the WMS must support the ability to manage multiple clients with diverse needs. A 3PL-focused WMS allows for the segregation of data and workflows for each client while offering centralized reporting and management.

- **Special requirements and customization:** Clients often have specific requirements, such as customized packaging, special handling instructions, or regulatory compliance. A WMS for 3PLs allows for customized workflows and services that accommodate these needs.

- **Variety of shipping methods:** A 3PL WMS integrates with various shipping carriers and methods, offering flexibility to accommodate different client preferences, from small parcel deliveries to freight shipments. The system can also optimize shipping routes and reduce costs.

- **Value-added activities:** 3PL providers often offer additional services such as assembly, kitting, or packaging. A WMS built for 3PLs manages these value-added activities and ensures that all associated tasks are completed correctly and efficiently.

- **Specialized billing:** Since 3PLs serve multiple clients with different pricing structures, a WMS designed for 3PLs includes sophisticated billing and invoicing capabilities. This allows providers to bill clients based on usage, services rendered, or other customized metrics.

FINDING THE RIGHT WMS FOR YOUR NEEDS

Each industry has unique challenges when it comes to warehouse management. Whether you're in retail, e-commerce, manufacturing, or 3PL, industry-specific WMS solutions are designed to address the specific needs and intricacies of your business. By choosing the right WMS, businesses can improve efficiency, reduce costs, and enhance customer satisfaction.

Retail: Focus on point-of-sale integration, managing multiple locations, and demand planning.

E-commerce: Prioritize fast order fulfillment, shipping integration, and direct customer communication.

Manufacturing: Focus on just-in-time inventory, production line timeliness, and instant visibility.

3PLs: Manage multiple clients, special requirements, and specialized billing.

Ultimately, the choice of WMS depends on the specific needs of your industry, and opting for a system built with your business in mind can lead to streamlined operations and enhanced growth potential.

INDUSTRY	KEY FOCUS AREAS	CORE FEATURES
Retail	Multi-location inventory, POS sync, demand forecasting	- POS Integration (real-time updates) - Store-level stock management - Demand planning tools for promotions & seasons
E-commerce	Speed, shipping, customer communication	- Fast order fulfillment workflows - Integrated shipping software (labels, tracking) - Real-time updates to customers
Manufacturing	Just-in-time inventory, production flow, procurement planning	- Inventory availability for production lines - Integration with procurement / planning tools - High inventory turnover support
3PLs	Multi-client needs, customization, billing	- Segmented client workflows & reporting - Support for kitting, special handling - Custom billing by usage or service

CHAPTER 4: KEY FEATURES TO LOOK FOR IN A WMS

When choosing a WMS, it's not just about checking boxes — it's about finding the right tools that will help your warehouse run smoother, smarter, and more efficiently. Here are some of the most important features to look for and why they matter.

INVENTORY MANAGEMENT

Your WMS should give you full control and visibility over your inventory — from the moment it enters your warehouse to the moment it leaves. Here are some key features to look for.

- **Cycle counts:** Whether you're doing them on a schedule, on-demand, or as part of a back count after a pick, cycle count options help you stay on top of inventory without shutting down operations.

- **Adjustment controls:** You'll want the ability to make inventory adjustments with proper controls — like limiting who can adjust, tracking reasons for changes, and handling different inventory types (damaged, hold, QA, etc.).

- **Activity history:** You should be able to see exactly when something was received, where it's been inside your facility, who touched it, and when it shipped. It's like a digital paper trail — but better.

- **Min/max parameters:** Set minimum and maximum inventory thresholds for each item or location. When stock drops below the minimum, the system can trigger replenishment tasks or alerts automatically.

- **Replenishment logic:** You should be able to define rules for when, how, and from where stock should be replenished — whether that's from bulk storage to forward pick areas, between zones, or across facilities. This ensures that fast-moving SKUs are always available where they're needed most, without manual intervention.

ORDER MANAGEMENT

A WMS should make order processing as easy as possible — from entering orders to getting them out the door. Here are some things to keep an eye on.

- **Flexible order entry:** Orders should be easy to key in manually or receive electronically through integrations (like EDI).
- **Product commitment rules:** Assign inventory based on customer needs — whether it's by lot code, consignee, or specific pallet configuration.
- **Special instructions and comments:** These should flow straight to the floor, so pickers know exactly what to do.
- **Label and document printing:** You should be able to easily print what you need — packing lists, BOLs, shipping labels, and more.
- **Load tracking:** Know what's on each trailer, how it's configured, and when it leaves. You should also be able to prioritize loads and schedule dock appointments without a headache.

REAL-TIME DATA

Real-time visibility is a game changer. Your WMS should give you up-to-date information so you can make fast, informed decisions — instead of finding out about problems after it's too late.

- **Live activity tracking:** See what's happening on the floor right now — not just at the end of the day.
- **Task scheduling and alerts:** Set up alerts for things like late appointments, inventory mismatches, or a driver arriving at the dock.
- **Proactive decision-making:** The right visibility lets you adjust your day as needed, helping prevent small issues from becoming big ones.

INTEGRATION WITH OTHER SYSTEMS

A WMS really shines when it plays well with other systems. Good integration capabilities help you streamline operations and make sure every part of your supply chain is connected.

- **ERP integration:** Sync inventory with procurement and production planning so teams aren't working in silos.
- **TMS integration:** Coordinate loads and dock scheduling, and unlock consolidation opportunities.
- **Parcel shipping integration:** Boost speed and accuracy in your small-package shipments with tools built for fast labeling and tracking.

BONUS

These integrations cut down on manual entry, reduce errors, and keep your whole operation aligned.

REPORTING & ANALYTICS

Your WMS collects a ton of data — but it needs to be presented in a way that actually helps you make decisions.

- **KPI-aligned reports:** Your reports should align with the metrics that matter most to you — whether that's shipping accuracy, on-time performance, or productivity.
- **Core reports to look for:**
    - Inventory balance (by item, lot, location)
    - Adjustment and movement logs
    - On-time shipping and fulfillment rates
    - Productivity by employee or process
    - Recall traceability reports
- **Profitability insight:** Great reporting helps you evaluate customers, processes, or areas that are making (or costing) you money.

MOBILE ACCESS & BARCODE SCANNING

A Modern WMS should support mobile devices and barcode scanning — for good reason.

- **Fewer errors:** Scanning eliminates mistakes caused by handwriting or manual data entry.
- **Faster work:** It takes a lot less time to scan than it does to write things down or type them in.
- **Better visibility:** Mobile access means managers can stay connected on the warehouse floor, not just behind a desk.
- **Improved employee experience:** A smoother system means less frustration and better productivity for your team.

SECURITY & COMPLIANCE

Your WMS should not only help you run your warehouse — it should also help protect your business.

- **User permissions:** Only the right people should have access to certain functions. Make sure your system has user-level controls to prevent unauthorized changes.
- **Audit trails:** Every action in the system should be tied to a user ID, time-stamped, and easy to trace.
- **Compliance support:** If your warehouse needs to comply with certain standards (like FDA, ISO, etc.), your WMS should help support documentation, product holds, recalls, and other compliance needs.
- **Data protection:** Whether you are cloud-based or on-premises, your WMS should follow best practices for data security to keep sensitive information safe.

CHAPTER 5: HOW TO IMPLEMENT A WMS

STEP-BY-STEP IMPLEMENTATION PROCESS

Implementing a WMS isn't just about flipping a switch—it's a project that touches every part of your operation. But don't worry—with the right plan, team, and mindset, it can be a game changer. Here's a breakdown of each step in the process, with tips to help you stay on track and be successful.

STEP 1: ASSESS YOUR NEEDS

- Before choosing any software, you need to understand exactly what you're working with.
- Walk through every process in your warehouse—receiving, picking, putaway, cycle counting, loading, shipping, appointments, billing, and more.
- Look for exceptions or edge cases. What doesn't follow the "normal" process? Those situations will matter when choosing features or building workflows.
- Don't forget about reporting needs, customer communication, and any custom labels, documents, or file formats.
- Make a list of what's working well—and what isn't. The pain points are what you'll want your new WMS to solve.
- Be intentional. Don't just carry over existing workflows without scrutiny. A WMS can automate your processes, but that will include the broken ones if you're not careful. Use a critical eye to decide what truly works and what needs to be rethought before you digitize it.

PRO TIP: Get input from across your team—floor staff, supervisors, accounting, customer service, and IT. Everyone sees the process differently, and they'll all be impacted by the change.

STEP 2: CHOOSE THE RIGHT WMS

Now that you know what you need, it's time to go shopping.

- Build a list of WMS vendors. Ask peers in your industry what they're using and how they like it.
- Look at systems that specialize in your industry (e-commerce, 3PL, manufacturing, etc.).
- Set up demos and come prepared with your real-life use cases. Don't settle for a generic walk-through—ask how their system will handle your process.
- Make a scorecard or checklist to compare systems apples-to-apples. Look at cost, features, support, upgrade paths, and user experience.

CHECKLIST TIP: Categorize your requirements into must-haves, nice-to-haves, and future wants. This will help you stay focused and avoid getting dazzled by flashy features you may never use.

STEP 3: PLAN & PREP YOUR WAREHOUSE

The warehouse needs to be ready to go when your WMS is.

- Communicate early and often with your team. Get them involved and excited. Change is easier when people feel included and prepared.
- Physically prep the warehouse:
  - Print and install location labels and signs.
  - Make sure you have the right barcode labels and printers.
  - Check that you have strong Wi-Fi coverage across the floor.
  - Test all devices—scanners, tablets, mobile carts, etc.—for compatibility.
- Get your inventory in shape. Do full cycle counts and correct discrepancies before go-live. Clean data leads to a smoother transition.

STEP 4: INTEGRATION & DATA MIGRATION

Your WMS doesn't work in a vacuum—it needs to talk to your other systems.

- Identify all systems that need to integrate: ERP, TMS, parcel shipping, accounting, customer portals, etc.
- Appoint someone to own the integration plan. This includes mapping fields, defining file formats, and tracking progress.
- Start collecting key data:
  - Item master
  - Inventory levels
  - Historical orders and receipts
  - Customer-specific requirements
- If you're migrating data, make sure it's clean and organized. Garbage in, garbage out.

BONUS TIP: Test your integrations thoroughly—and more than once. Include edge cases and "bad data" scenarios to make sure the system handles them properly.

STEP 5: TRAIN YOUR TEAM

This is where your WMS lives or dies—training is that important.

- Identify your super users—the go-to people who'll help others during and after go-live.
- Partner closely with your vendor for training. Make sure key users know the system inside and out.
- Schedule training thoughtfully. Stagger sessions if needed so that warehouse operations don't grind to a halt.

- Simulate real-life scenarios so your team gets hands-on experience before the system goes live.
- Create cheat sheets or quick-reference guides for common tasks.

PRO TIP: Keep the vibe positive. Change can be stressful, so celebrate small wins and encourage open communication as your team learns.

STEP 6: ONGOING SUPPORT & MAINTENANCE

Go-live is just the beginning—support is what keeps everything running smoothly.

- Understand your vendor’s support process. Is it 24/7? Is there a help desk? How quickly do they respond?
- Know how updates and upgrades are handled. Are they automatic or do they require downtime?
- Ask about post-go-live support. Many vendors offer extra help during the first few weeks, which can be a lifesaver.
- Assign internal roles for long-term system ownership: Who will train new hires, manage user access, and monitor performance?

EXPERT TIP: Keep evolving! As you grow and refine your operation, revisit how you use the WMS. It should grow with you—not hold you back.

CHALLENGES & HOW TO OVERCOME THEM

Implementing a WMS is a big step forward for your operation, but like any meaningful change, it comes with its fair share of challenges. The good news? Many of these can be anticipated—and planned for—with the right mindset and a solid strategy. Here are a few common roadblocks we see, along with practical tips for navigating them successfully.

STEP 1: GETTING EMPLOYEE BUY-IN

Let's start with the people side of things. Your software can only be as effective as the people using it, which is why employee buy-in is one of the most critical pieces of a successful WMS implementation.

THE CHALLENGE: You can have the best WMS in the world, but if your team isn't on board, it won't get you very far. Change can feel intimidating, especially if your employees are used to doing things a certain way.

HOW TO HANDLE IT: Involve your team early and often. Make it clear that this new system is being brought in to support them—not to make their jobs harder. Ask for feedback, include them in decision-making where you can, and identify your "natural leaders" on the team to become super users. These are the folks who can help champion change and train others with a sense of trust and experience.

Also, don't skimp on training. Make sure it's hands-on, digestible, and tailored to different roles. The more confident your team feels, the smoother the transition will be.

STEP 2: INTEGRATION WITH OTHER SYSTEMS

Next up: making your systems play nice together. Your WMS won't live in a silo— it needs to integrate smoothly with other critical systems like ERPs, TMSs, parcel software, and more.

THE CHALLENGE: WMS software rarely operates in a vacuum—it needs to talk to your ERP, shipping software, accounting systems, and more. Getting those connections right can be tricky.

HOW TO HANDLE IT: Start with a clear list of what systems need to connect and what data needs to move between them. Choose a point person or a small team responsible for integration— they'll be your go-to experts. Communicate early with customers and vendors if anything on their end might be affected. And most importantly: Test, test, and test again. Simulate real scenarios before going live to catch any hiccups early.

STEP 3: EXPECTING THE UNEXPECTED

Finally, let's talk about one of the biggest truths of any big project: There will be surprises. No matter how much planning you do, curveballs are bound to pop up. The key is to be prepared to roll with them.

THE CHALLENGE: Even with the best planning, something unexpected always comes up—whether it's a data issue, a timeline shift, or a feature you realize you need mid-project.

HOW TO HANDLE IT: Go in with a plan, but also build in some flexibility. Give yourself a little extra buffer in your timeline. Be open to rethinking workflows if they're no longer serving you in the new system. It helps to have a team culture that's open to change and ready to adapt when things don't go exactly as planned.

STEP 4: MANAGING COSTS & STAYING ON BUDGET

Let's talk money—because it matters. A WMS is a big investment, and while it can absolutely deliver long-term savings and efficiency, the implementation phase is where budgets can start to slip if you're not careful.

THE CHALLENGE: Even with a detailed budget in place, it's easy for costs to creep up unexpectedly. Things like integration with customer systems, purchasing additional hardware or scanners, unforeseen training needs, or even small changes to your original plan (aka "scope creep") can quietly chip away at your budget.

HOW TO HANDLE IT: Start by being thorough during the planning and proposal phase. Make sure you and your vendor are crystal clear on what's included—and just as importantly, what's not. If you need integrations, specialized hardware, or ongoing support, get it priced and documented up front.

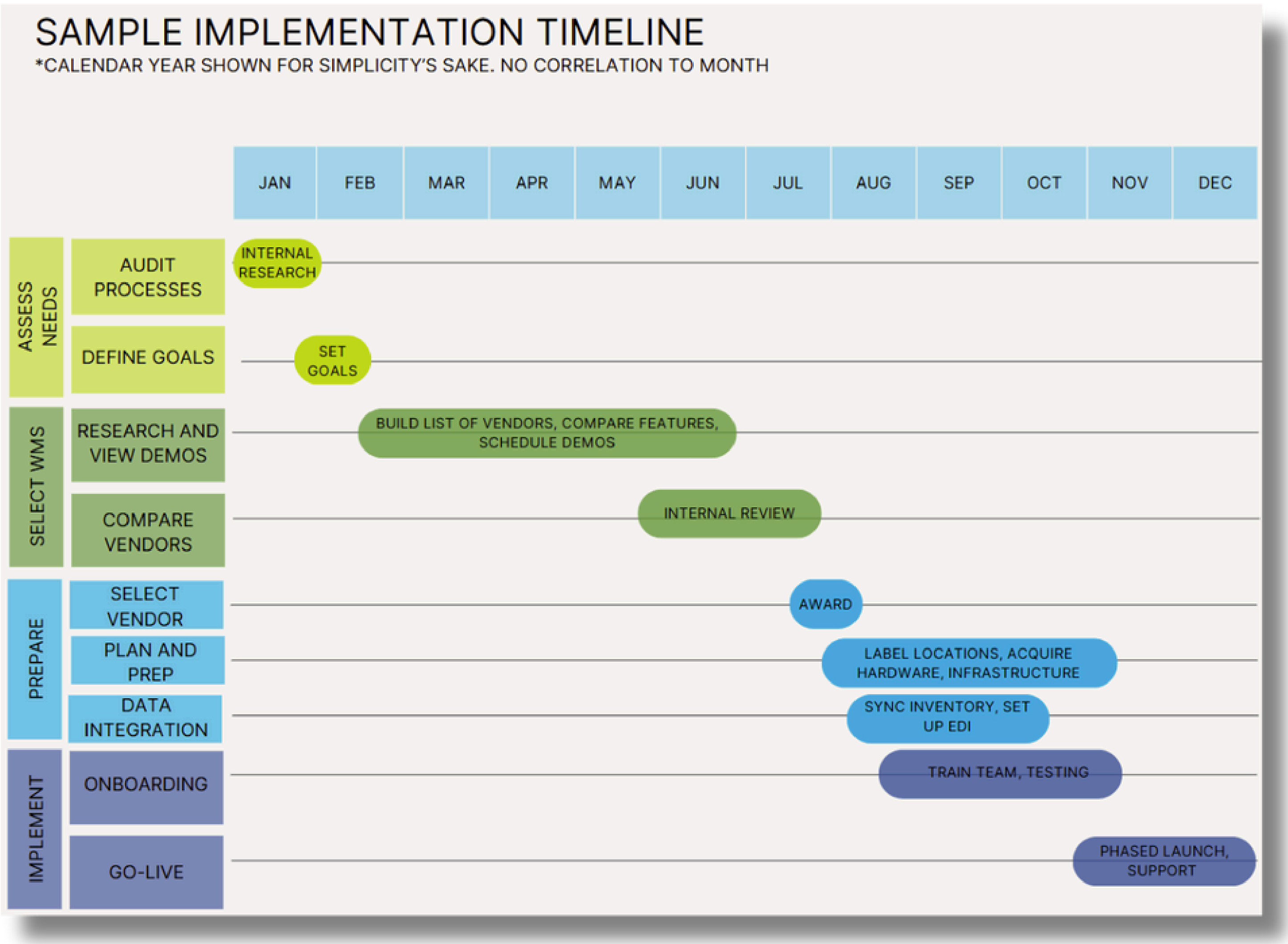
Know your business requirements inside and out. When your team is aligned on the must-haves, nice-to-haves, and future wants, it's easier to stay focused and avoid unnecessary add-ons during the build.

Keep an eye out for "scope creep"—those small "can we just add this?" requests that add up over time. Call it out early when something strays from the original plan, and keep everyone grounded in the agreed-upon goals and priorities.

Finally, don't forget to budget for the future. Continued training, user support, and even new hire onboarding with the WMS should all be part of your long-term success plan.

FINAL THOUGHT:

The goal isn't a *perfect* implementation—it's a *successful* one. And that often comes down to communication, preparation, and being willing to adapt. A good WMS partner (like us!) will walk alongside you every step of the way to help make that process smoother and more manageable.

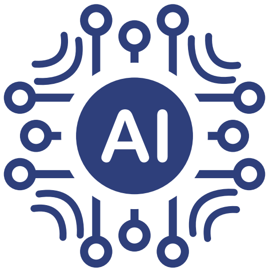


CHAPTER 6: THE FUTURE OF WMS

TECHNOLOGY TRENDS SHAPING WMS

We've talked about how WMS has evolved into a powerful and flexible tool, but the journey doesn't stop there. The logistics industry continues to change rapidly, and new technologies are making their way into warehouses of all shapes and sizes. Even if your operation isn't quite ready to implement these tools, knowing what's out there (and what's coming) can help you stay ahead of the curve.

Here are some of the innovations shaping the future of WMS.

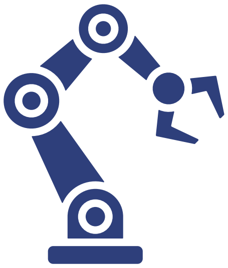


ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE (AI)

AI in WMS can help analyze huge amounts of data and turn it into actionable insights. Think of AI like an extra brain for your system—helping you spot patterns, highlight inefficiencies, and even find ways to improve your workflows. Whether it's forecasting labor needs or recommending better pick paths, AI can help make smarter decisions, faster.

MACHINE LEARNING (ML)

Machine learning takes AI a step further by allowing your system to "learn" from past behavior and get better over time. In the world of WMS, ML might help predict order volume spikes, identify slow-moving inventory before it becomes a problem, or even recommend adjustments to staffing or storage layout. It's like predictive analytics on autopilot.



ROBOTICS

Robots are no longer just science fiction. From robotic arms that pick and pack to autonomous mobile robots (AMRs) that move inventory across your floor, these machines are making warehouses faster and safer. Some companies are even using drones for cycle counts—cutting hours of labor down to minutes.

INTERNET OF THINGS (IoT)

IoT refers to a network of connected devices that communicate with each other in real time. In your warehouse, that could mean smart sensors tracking temperature-sensitive inventory, equipment that monitors its own maintenance needs, or forklifts that report their own movements. All of this data feeds into your WMS and gives you better visibility and control.

CLOUD-FIRST & EDGE COMPUTING

Cloud-based WMS solutions continue to dominate, but edge computing is becoming more common too. This means data can be processed closer to where it's generated (like on a mobile device or sensor), which helps reduce lag and improves real-time responsiveness. It's all about faster decision-making and smoother operations.

DIGITAL TWINS

A digital twin is a virtual representation of your warehouse that mirrors real-time conditions. With it, you can simulate changes, test new layouts, or plan for different order volumes—all without physically changing a thing. This is great for strategic planning, process testing, or visualizing growth before making investments.

CUSTOMIZATION & ADAPTABILITY

If there's one thing we know for sure about the supply chain world, it's that things don't stay the same for long. Whether it's new customer demands, sustainability pressures, or a sudden shift in your fulfillment strategy, your warehouse needs to stay nimble. That's where customization and adaptability in your WMS really shine.

A HISTORY OF EVOLVING NEEDS

The WMS of the past was built to handle pallets and cases on a traditional shipping dock. But fast forward a bit, and you've seen WMS evolve to manage:

E-commerce fulfillment (like high-volume small parcel orders)

Omnichannel distribution (handling retail, wholesale, and DTC all under one roof)

More advanced traceability (for food, pharma, and other regulated industries)

Returns management (as reverse logistics became a critical part of operations)

WMS has adapted to all of it—because it had to.

CUSTOMIZATION OPENS THE DOOR TO WHAT'S NEXT

The beauty of many modern WMS platforms is their ability to be customized. This doesn't just mean changing button colors or adding a custom field (though those are nice too). We're talking about:

- **Building custom workflows** to match your team's exact process
- **Creating logic for specialized pick paths or storage rules**
- **Integrating new modules** as your business adds services (like kitting or light manufacturing)
- **Tailoring reporting and dashboards** to match KPIs that actually matter to your business

Having a WMS that can evolve alongside your operations means you don't have to rip-and-replace every time your needs change—you just adjust and move forward.

ADAPTING TO THE FUTURE

As we look ahead, businesses will continue to expect more out of their WMS. Some areas where adaptability will be especially important include:

- **Omnichannel Agility:** With customers shopping via multiple channels, fulfillment has to be fast, smart, and seamless.
- **Sustainability efforts:** Companies will need tools to track eco-friendly packaging, carbon-conscious routing, or optimized storage to reduce footprint.
- **Custom service offerings:** 3PLs especially will need to adapt quickly to unique client requests and service types.
- **Data-driven decisions:** Businesses will expect more actionable insights directly from their WMS dashboards and reports.

Even if your business isn't quite there yet, choosing a WMS that gives you the room to grow into these capabilities puts you a step ahead.

CHAPTER 7: HOW TO CHOOSE THE RIGHT WMS FOR YOUR BUSINESS

ASSESSING YOUR WAREHOUSE NEEDS

Before you even start comparing WMS vendors, the most important step is understanding *your own operation*. A WMS is only as good as its fit—and no two warehouses are exactly alike. That's why taking the time to carefully evaluate your current processes, challenges, and goals is crucial to choosing the right solution.

Start by walking through your day-to-day operations with a critical eye. How do you receive product? How do you move it through the building? What does your picking process look like? How do you ship orders out the door? Are there bottlenecks or parts of the process that feel overly manual or time-consuming? Make note of those pain points—they'll be key drivers in what you need a WMS to solve.

You'll also want to dig into the details. Are there customer-specific requirements you have to follow? Do you need to track lot codes, expiration dates, or serial numbers? Are there documents or reports that you generate regularly or that are unique to your operation? The more you understand your exceptions and edge cases, the better equipped you'll be to find a system that can handle them—or work around them with customization.

Another important area to explore is how you want your business to grow. Maybe you're looking to expand into e-Commerce or bring on more complex customers. Or maybe your current system just doesn't give you the real-time data you need to make decisions confidently. Thinking ahead to where you *want* to be in a few years will help you choose a WMS that can scale and evolve with you.

And don't forget to involve your team. Operations, IT, finance, customer service—they all touch different pieces of the puzzle. Getting their input now can save a lot of headaches later and give you a clearer picture of what the system needs to do for everyone involved.

Bottom line? The more you know about how your warehouse operates today—and what you want it to look like tomorrow—the better positioned you'll be to choose a WMS that's not just a fit for now, but for the future too.

QUESTIONS TO ASK WMS VENDORS

Once you've got a handle on what your business needs, the next step is knowing how to evaluate the vendors you're speaking with. Choosing a WMS isn't just about flashy features—it's about finding a partner that truly understands your operation and can support your long-term goals. **A great place to start is asking whether the system is built for your specific industry.** Many WMS solutions are designed with particular use cases in mind—retail, 3PL, manufacturing, e-commerce—and choosing one that aligns with your business ensures you're not constantly trying to force a square peg into a round hole.

Integration is another critical piece. **Ask how easily the WMS can connect with your existing tools—ERP, TMS, accounting software, shipping platforms, and even things like BI tools or CRM systems.** The more seamless the integration, the less manual work and patching you'll have to do later on. And don't just take a vendor's word for it—ask to see examples and use cases, or even speak with a current customer who has a similar tech stack.

Support is also something you'll want to dig into. **Find out what kind of support is offered—not just during implementation, but afterward.** Will you have a dedicated rep? Is support included in your subscription or is it billed separately? Is there after-hours coverage? Try to get a feel for how hands-on and responsive the support is. A great product can be hampered by poor support.

Other great questions include:

- How often is the system updated?
- Can you customize features or workflows?
- What does training look like?
- How long does implementation typically take?

Don't be afraid to ask for detailed answers—your warehouse operations depend on this decision, and any vendor worth your time will respect that and be happy to walk you through the details.

PRICING MODELS

When it comes to WMS pricing, there's no one-size-fits-all model—which is actually a good thing. Most solutions come with **up-front implementation fees**, which typically cover setup, configuration, integration, and training. After that, you'll usually have **ongoing monthly or annual fees**, depending on the pricing model. Some systems use a **subscription-based model (SaaS)** where you pay per month or per year for access, while others offer **perpetual licensing**, which is a larger one-time fee plus ongoing maintenance costs. You might also see vendors that charge based on **transaction volume** (how many orders you ship) or **user count** (how many logins your team needs). The key takeaway: There are lots of pricing structures out there, so with the right conversations and clarity about your needs, you can find a model that fits both your budget and growth goals.

CONCLUSION: MAKING A WMS WORK FOR YOU

A WMS isn't just another piece of software — it's a game changer for how your operation runs day to day. Whether you're looking to boost efficiency, reduce costs, improve accuracy, or simply get a better handle on your inventory, a WMS brings the tools to make that happen.

With the right system in place, you get real-time visibility into your operation, powerful automation that saves time and cuts down on manual work, and better tracking so nothing slips through the cracks. Features like barcode scanning, inventory management, mobile access, and robust reporting help you make smarter decisions, faster.

And when it comes to long-term benefits? You're looking at more accurate shipments, happier customers, more productive employees, and a system that grows with you. Whether you're just getting started or upgrading from something that no longer fits, a WMS can help take your warehouse to the next level.

NEXT STEPS

Now that you have a solid understanding of what a WMS is and why it matters, it's time to start thinking about what comes next. Here are some practical steps to help guide your journey toward finding the right solution.

IDENTIFY YOUR NEEDS

- Start by understanding your current pain points and goals.
- Are you outgrowing paper processes? Struggling with inventory accuracy? Needing better visibility?

SPEAK WITH KEY TEAM MEMBERS

Include voices from every area of your business:

- **Operations** (how the floor runs)
- **IT** (integration and security)
- **Accounting** (cost tracking and billing)
- **Customer service** (order accuracy and visibility)
- **Management/executives/owners** (big-picture strategy and investment)

ASSEMBLE A WMS SEARCH TEAM

Assign a small group of stakeholders to own the evaluation and decision-making process. Make sure they represent different departments, so you capture a full view of your operation — not just how things should work, but how they actually run day to day.

Suggested roles to include:

- **Warehouse Manager or Supervisor**
  - They know the current processes, bottlenecks, and what features will (or won't) work on the floor.
- **IT or Systems Administrator**
  - They'll ensure the WMS integrates well with your existing systems (ERP, TMS, scanners, etc.) and can evaluate technical capabilities and limitations.
- **Inventory or Operations Lead**
  - They understand the movement and control of goods, and can speak to things like cycle counts, replenishment needs, and data accuracy.
- **Customer Service or Account Manager**
  - These teams deal with downstream effects of warehouse issues — late orders, mis-picks, communication gaps — and will push for features that improve customer experience.
- **Finance or Billing Analyst**
  - They'll want to understand how the WMS supports billing logic, cost tracking, and reporting, especially for 3PL or complex fulfillment environments.
- **Executive Sponsor or Operations Director**
  - They can help align the decision with larger business goals, timelines, and budget.

Pro Tip: If your team is large, keep the core search group small but involve others through interviews or process walk-throughs to gather input without slowing things down.

DEFINE YOUR REQUIREMENTS

Break it into categories:

- **Must-haves:** essential features you can't operate without
- **Nice-to-haves:** valuable, but not critical features
- **Wish list:** dream features that could be game changers down the line

START RESEARCHING PROVIDERS

- Look into WMS vendors that align with your type of business and operational complexity.
- Explore online reviews, attend webinars, and ask others in your network what they're using.

CREATE & SHARE AN RFP (REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL)

- If your process is formal, an RFP can help you collect consistent, detailed information from vendors.
- It also helps clarify your priorities and gives vendors a chance to tailor their response to your needs.

PLAN HOW YOU'LL COMPARE VENDORS

- Decide what criteria matter most: cost, features, ease of use, integration, support, scalability, etc.
- Build a comparison matrix or scoring sheet to keep things objective and organized.

START THE CONVERSATION

- Begin booking discovery calls and demos with your top vendors.
- Bring your team to the demos so everyone sees how the system would work in your environment.

LET'S TALK WHEN YOU'RE READY

Choosing a WMS is a big decision, and we know there's a lot to think about. If you're just starting to explore options or have questions about what might be a good fit for your operation, we'd be happy to help. No hard pitches, just real conversations with people who understand warehouses.

You can reach out for a consultation, schedule a demo, or simply ask us a few questions. Wherever you are in your journey, we're here when you need us.

GET IN TOUCH

WMS NEEDS ASSESSMENT CHECKLIST

Use this checklist to get a clear picture of what your warehouse really needs before talking to vendors.

DAILY OPERATIONS

- How do we receive products? (e.g., ASN, blind receiving, manual counts)
- How do we put products away and assign locations?
- What does our picking process look like?
- How do we manage replenishments and transfers?
- How are orders shipped and loaded out?
- How do we handle returns?

INVENTORY MANAGEMENT

- Do we track lot codes, serial numbers, or expiration dates?
- Do we manage damaged, hold, QA, or other inventory types?
- How often do we cycle count or adjust inventory?
- Do we need traceability or recall functionality?

CUSTOMER & COMPLIANCE REQUIREMENTS

- Do our customers have unique rules or formats for orders/shipments?
- Are there any special documents or reports we need to generate?
- Do we need to meet any industry-specific compliance or certifications?

TECHNOLOGY & INTEGRATION

- What systems does our WMS need to connect with? (e.g., ERP, TMS, parcel software)
- Do we need real-time data sharing between systems?
- What equipment do we currently use? (scanners, printers, mobile devices)
- Do we need to purchase additional hardware?

TEAM INVOLVEMENT

- Who will be impacted by a new WMS? (Ops, IT, Finance, CS, etc.)
- Have we gathered input from all departments?
- Who will be involved in training and rollout?

GROWTH & GOALS

- What isn't working well today that we want to fix?
- Are we expanding to new channels (eCommerce, retail, etc.)?
- Do we need a system that can scale with business growth?
- What are our top 3 goals with implementing a WMS?

TOP QUESTIONS TO ASK WMS VENDORS

GENERAL FIT & INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE

- Does your system support the specific needs of my industry (e.g., 3PL, eCommerce, manufacturing, retail)?
- Can you share examples or case studies of similar businesses using your WMS?
- How customizable is the system to our unique workflows?

FEATURES & FUNCTIONALITY

- What are the core features included out of the box?
- Are there any features/modules that are considered add-ons? What are the costs?
- How does your WMS handle inventory tracking, cycle counts, and product traceability?
- Does the system support multiple picking strategies (e.g., wave, zone, batch picking)?
- How is reporting handled—are there built-in reports, dashboards, and KPI tracking tools?

INTEGRATION CAPABILITIES

- What systems does your WMS currently integrate with (ERP, TMS, parcel, ecommerce platforms)?
- What integration formats are supported (e.g., EDI, XML, API)?
- How flexible is the integration process if we have unique customers or internal requirements?

IMPLEMENTATION & ONBOARDING

- What does a typical implementation timeline look like?
- What is required from our team during implementation?
- Do you offer data migration support?
- How do you support change management and employee training during go-live?

SUPPORT & SERVICE

- What level of customer support is included? (e.g., hours of operation, ticketing system, live support)
- Do you provide a dedicated account manager or implementation specialist?
- How do you handle system upgrades and patches?

SCALABILITY & FUTURE-PROOFING

- How does your WMS scale with a growing business?
- Are there limits to the number of users, locations, or transactions?
- How are new features or enhancements rolled out?

SECURITY & COMPLIANCE

- How do you ensure data security and system uptime?
- Does your system support audit trails and user-based permissions?
- Can the system help us maintain or achieve certifications (e.g., FDA, ISO)?

COST & ROI

- What is the full cost breakdown (licensing, implementation, training, support)?
- What are some common hidden or unexpected costs to be aware of?
- What kind of ROI have other clients seen after implementing your system?

WMS READINESS CHECKLIST

UNDERSTANDING YOUR BUSINESS NEEDS

- Have we documented every step of our current warehouse processes (receiving, picking, shipping, inventory, etc.)? ◯ Yes ◯ No
- Have we identified problem areas or inefficiencies in our current operations? ◯ Yes ◯ No
- Do we have special customer requirements or unique workflows that need to be supported? ◯ Yes ◯ No
- Have we considered our future goals and how a WMS could help us scale? ◯ Yes ◯ No

INTERNAL ALIGNMENT & BUY-IN

- Have we talked with all key departments (IT, Operations, Customer Service, Finance, Management)? ◯ Yes ◯ No
- Have we assembled a team to lead the WMS search and implementation process? ◯ Yes ◯ No
- Are employees aware that a system change is coming and included in early conversations? ◯ Yes ◯ No

FEATURE REQUIREMENTS

- Have we created a list of must-haves, nice-to-have, and wish list features? ◯ Yes ◯ No
- Do we know what reporting and analytics we need from the system? ◯ Yes ◯ No
- Have we considered integration needs with ERP, TMS, parcel, or other software? ◯ Yes ◯ No

TECHNICAL READINESS

- Do we have access to our existing data (inventory, item master, history, etc.)? ◯ Yes ◯ No
- Have we assessed our hardware needs (barcode scanners, label printers, Wi-Fi, etc.)? ◯ Yes ◯ No
- Are we aware of any IT constraints that may impact implementation or integration? ◯ Yes ◯ No

BUDGET & PRICING

- Have we established a budget for both upfront and ongoing WMS costs? ◯ Yes ◯ No
- Are we aware of hidden costs like integration, hardware, and training? ◯ Yes ◯ No
- Do we understand the different pricing models (subscription, licensing, user-based, etc.)? ◯ Yes ◯ No

VENDOR SELECTION PROCESS

- Have we created a list of potential WMS vendors? ◯ Yes ◯ No
- Have we scheduled demos and developed a comparison scorecard or evaluation method? ◯ Yes ◯ No
- Do we have a list of key questions to ask each vendor? ◯ Yes ◯ No

IMPLEMENTATION PLANNING

- Do we have a realistic implementation timeline and go-live goal? ◯ Yes ◯ No
- Have we planned for staff training, testing, and data migration? ◯ Yes ◯ No
- Are we prepared to remain flexible and adapt during the implementation process? ◯ Yes ◯ No

SC CODEWORKS

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THANK YOU

FOR MORE INFORMATION OR TO SPEAK WITH A MEMBER OF OUR TEAM PLEASE CONTACT US

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